Discussion questions

The Bottomless Popcorn Paradox · for reading aloud at home, book clubs and classrooms

Pick two or three — not all of them. There are no wrong answers here, only unfinished ones. The best answers start with "because."

Before reading

1. Look at the cover. What is the bucket doing? What do you think bottomless means?
2. The title has a tricky word: paradox — something that sounds impossible but is somehow true. What could be impossible about a bucket of popcorn?
3. On the back cover, Jiwoo has a plan: not one sip of anything. What do you predict will happen?

During reading — chapter stops

Chapter 1 · Bottomless *page 1*

1. Maya's mom says, "Get a small popcorn. Drink water. Have fun." The girls answer, "Yep yep yep." Were they listening? How can you tell?
2. Jiwoo reads the sign and thinks, "Like a magic well. Like a promise of forever." What does bottomless promise? Who is making the promise?

Chapter 2 · As a Friend *page 5*

1. Jiwoo tells us her soccer practice "will become important later." What do you predict?
2. Her mom says, "Okay. Your choice." Why do you think she let Jiwoo choose?

Chapter 3 · Eight Minutes *page 10*

1. Jiwoo drank "Two sips. Maybe three." Then she had to go — a LOT. What do you think caused it? (Hold on to your answer.)
2. She sat in the bathroom "feeling betrayed." Betrayed by whom — or by what?

Chapter 4 · A State of Mind *page 13*

1. Jiwoo says, "Hydration is a state of mind." What does she mean? Where did that idea come from?
2. Lumi wants to write Jiwoo's words down "Word for word." Why would a scientist want the exact words?

Chapter 5 · Twenty Minutes In *page 17*

1. Jiwoo eats "handful after handful without remembering eating any of them." Has your hand ever kept going while your mind was somewhere else?
2. She tells herself "the movie is just very intense right now." Is that the real reason she feels strange? What clue does the book give you?

Chapter 6 · The Thirst Department *page 21*

1. Explain the Thirst Department to someone who hasn't read the book.
2. Jiwoo asks, "So I'm not… hungry?" Lumi only says, "You tell me." Why doesn't Lumi just give her the answer?

Chapter 7 · You Okay? *page 26*

1. "Maya always asks the right question." Why is "You okay?" the right question?
2. Jiwoo says, "It wasn't the movie water at all." What had she left out for a whole year? Why do you think she never thought of it?

Chapter 8 · Writing Over *page 31*

1. In the car, Jiwoo is "writing over the old idea with a new one." Have you ever changed your mind about something? What helped?
2. Jiwoo learns two things. Lumi says the second one "is the bigger discovery." Why might finding a wrong reason matter more than hearing a bell?

After reading — the big questions

1. Lumi says, "The bell rings whether you're listening or not." What helps you hear your own bells?
2. On the Lightning Kick day, four things were true (page 46). Jiwoo picked "the one she could see." Why is the reason you can see so easy to believe?
3. Jiwoo's new reason is the water cooler. Use Lumi's four questions on page 47: how could she check it?
4. Some kids are born with loud bells and some with quiet ones. Lumi says, "Neither bell is broken." What could someone with a quiet bell practice?
5. Nobody in this story says popcorn is bad. The book points to a combination instead. Why do you think the author wrote it that way?

In the car, at dinner — short versions for families

- What did your body text you today?
- Did you hear one of your bells late today?
- Was there a reason today that you checked twice?

There are no wrong answers here. There are unfinished ones. — L.